

Théah in a Nutshell

7th Sea 1st Edition history & nation reference for Maria Jose Torres y Soldano

Player-facing synopsis • focused on what an educated young Castillian noblewoman would plausibly know

1. The 30-second version

Théah resembles 17th-century Europe, but its politics are shaped by real sorcery, the Vaticine Church, the legacy of the Prophets, and very recent wars. Maria lives at an especially unstable moment: Eisen has just been shattered by the War of the Cross; Castille is being invaded by Montaigne; the Vaticine Church has no Hierophant; Cardinal Verdugo's Inquisition is expanding its reach; and El Vago is quietly protecting young King Sandoval and resisting threats to Castille.

2. A short historical spine

Event	Why it matters
1 AV - The First Prophet	Preaches Theus, condemns sorcery, and emphasizes humanity's intelligence and free will. His faith eventually becomes the official religion of the old Empire.
305-306 AV - The Second Prophet	Comes from the East/Crescent world and also condemns sorcery. His death and legacy help set the stage for later hostility between Vaticine Théah and the Crescent Empire.
c. 1000 AV - The Third Prophet	Appears in Castille, overturns the sorcerous nobility, renews crusading conflict with the Crescents, and eventually shifts the center of the Vaticine Church from Vodacce to Castille after the Hierophant War. He also creates the Inquisition to hunt sorcery.
1100s-1312 - Crusading era	Centuries of conflict with the Crescent Empire end after the Poor Knights of the Prophet are condemned; the Church closes the Crescent borders to the faithful, with limited Vodacce trade continuing.
1517 - Matthias Lieber and Objectionism	Eisen monk Matthias Lieber challenges Church authority and corruption. After excommunication, he returns to Eisen, uses the printing press, and translates scripture into Low Eisen. Objectionism spreads across Théah.
War of the Cross - 30 years	Religious conflict between Vaticines and Objectionists explodes in Eisen. Nearly every nation contributes forces, but Eisen bears the destruction. The war ends through exhaustion; roughly a third of Eisen's population is dead, the country is broken, and religious tolerance increases elsewhere.
1658-1659 - Rise of Avalon & the Armada	Queen Elaine unites the Glamour Isles, rejects Vaticine authority, and elevates sailors socially. Castille launches a great Armada against Avalon; the campaign fails, and Avalon's naval reputation soars.
1664-1666 onward - Montaigne crisis and war	Montaigne's king openly admits sorcery. Verdugo raises a largely Castillian Church army against Montaigne in 1666. Montegue defeats it, pursues the retreat into Castille, and the conflict becomes the ongoing Montaigne-Castille War.
Now	Castille has lost nearly a quarter of its territory to Montaigne. Montaigne's momentum has stalled after forces were split toward Ussura. Castille and Montaigne are locked in a stand-off while the Church remains without a Hierophant.

3. Religion: the fault line beneath the politics

Vaticine

The dominant Church of the Prophets. Historically it encouraged education, science, universities and the study of Creation. Castille is its institutional home and is the most devoutly Vaticine nation.

Objectionism

Born from Matthias Lieber's reform movement. Objectionists share the basic faith in Theus and the Prophets, but reject the idea that the institutional Church must stand between humanity and Theus. Scripture, direct faith, charity and good works are central. Eisen remains divided between Vaticines and Objectionists.

The current Inquisition

The Inquisition was created by the Third Prophet and was originally checked by the Hierophant. With the Hierophant missing, Cardinal Esteban Verdugo has expanded its targets beyond sorcery to Objectionists, scholars, books and research. It is strongest in Castille. The Invisible College and El Vago are specifically identified as forces resisting its worst excesses.

Maria note: Faith in Theus does not require uncritical loyalty to Verdugo or every act performed in the Church's name. That distinction is entirely compatible with the setting.

4. The nations Maria should have in her head

Castille

Home. Seat of the Vaticine Church; highly educated; young King Sandoval is politically vulnerable. El Vago has repeatedly protected him. Montaigne currently occupies nearly a quarter of Castille. Castillians have long memories of foreign invasion.

Language relevance for Maria: Castille; Théan is especially relevant through Church/education.

Eisen

The battlefield and principal victim of the War of the Cross. Now divided into seven königreiches ruled by Eisenfürsten. Its people have enormous military experience; many work abroad as mercenaries, soldiers and bodyguards.

Language relevance for Maria: Eisen is immediately useful to Maria because of the Captain and historically plausible because Eisen's recent catastrophe shaped continental politics. High Eisen is a separate elite/private language.

Montaigne

Cultural powerhouse and Castille's present enemy. Its king openly acknowledged sorcery; Verdugo's attack in 1666 backfired when Montegue defeated the Church army and carried the war into Castille. Montaigne currently holds Castillian territory.

Language relevance for Maria: Montaigne is arguably Maria's most obvious foreign political language: enemy officers, occupied territory, diplomacy, intelligence and court politics.

Vodacce

Former seat of the Vaticine Church and still enormously influential inside its hierarchy; Vodacce cardinals retain major political weight. The country is divided among seven merchant princes and is famous for ruthless intrigue and Fate Witches.

Language relevance for Maria: Vodacce is highly relevant to a politically minded Castillian noblewoman because Church politics and Castillian politics overlap.

Avalon

Queen Elaine united Avalon, Inismore and the Highland Marches in 1658, rejected Vaticine control, and built a formidable maritime power. Avalon's sailors/privateers prey on Castillian, Vodacce and Montaigne shipping. Castille's Armada against Avalon failed.

Language relevance for Maria: Useful for naval/international affairs, but less immediately central to Maria's current life than Eisen, Montaigne or Vodacce.

Vendel / Vestenmannavnjar

The Vendel League has become an economic power, especially after Eisen's collapse. The Guilder dominates commerce. Vendel is largely Objectivist; traditional Vestenmannavnjar retain older beliefs. Vendel and Vodacce are engaged in a commercial struggle.

Language relevance for Maria: Potentially useful for commerce and international travel, but Maria is not being built as a merchant.

Ussura

Culturally distant, difficult to invade, and tied to Matushka/Grandmother Winter. Its Orthodox Church follows the First Prophet rather than the later Prophets. Montaigne has recently diverted forces toward Ussura.

Language relevance for Maria: Politically noteworthy, but probably a lower-priority language for Maria unless Gabe's campaign turns east.

Crescent Empire

Historically intertwined with Castille through trade and cultural influence, then cast as the enemy in centuries of Vaticine crusading. After the crusading era, Church policy sharply restricted contact, though Vodacce retained a trade connection.

Language relevance for Maria: Historically fascinating for Castille, but not automatically a practical language for fourteen-year-old Maria without a specific educational reason.

5. Maria's language-planning cheat sheet

From the Player's Guide language table, a Castillian Hero pays the base costs below. Maria has Linguist, reducing each purchased language by 1 point (minimum 1 unless its normal cost is 0). Literacy normally adds 1 HP. Castillian Education already gives Maria spoken/read/written Théan, so do not buy Théan again.

Language	Castillian base	With Linguist	Maria relevance
Castille	0	0	Native
Eisen	2	1	Immediate party need + recent continental history
Montaigne	1	1	Current enemy; occupied Castillian territory
Vodacce	1	1	Church hierarchy and politics
Avalon	2	1	Naval/political relevance
Vendel	2	1	Trade/economic relevance
Ussura	3	2	More distant; current Montaigne involvement
Crescent	2	1	Deep Castillian historical connection; needs a personal rationale
High Eisen	3	2	Elite/private Eisen speech; much more specialized
Teodoran	4	3	Scholarly/obscure; little reason for Maria
Théan	2	FREE via Castillian Education	Church/scripture/scholarship

6. A useful priority lens for Maria

This is not a final purchase list; it is a character-logic guide. Eisen has become an immediate practical need. Montaigne and Vodacce have exceptionally strong political reasons for a young Castillian noblewoman interested in people, influence and power. Avalon, Vendel, Ussura and Crescent become stronger choices if Maria's upbringing, Papa's travels, tutors, or Gabe's campaign give her direct exposure.

7. What Maria would reasonably know without Scholar: History

Maria does not need the Scholar Skill to know the broad history above. With Noble, Castillian Education, University, Faith, Courtier and her family background, the major religious wars, the state of Eisen, the Montaigne invasion, the Church crisis and the major powers of Théah are ordinary educated-noble knowledge. Scholar: History would represent deeper academic study rather than basic political literacy.

8. At-the-table memory hooks

Eisen = the country the religious war broke.

Montaigne = the enemy currently inside Castille.

Vodacce = the Church moved away from there, but Vodacce never stopped pulling Church strings.

Avalon = newly united island power; Castille's Armada failed against it.

Vendel = money, Guilds, Guilder, rising commercial power.

Ussura = old ways, First Prophet, Matushka, very hard to invade.

Castille = Church seat + young king + invasion + Verdugo + El Vago.

Maria = faithful, educated, observant - and perfectly capable of distinguishing Theus from the ambitions of men speaking in His name.

9. Source note

This handout is intentionally based on the 7th Sea 1st Edition Player's Guide supplied for the campaign. Key reference areas: Théah history/current events (around pp. 29-33), nation overviews (roughly pp. 38-49 and nation summaries), Vaticine Church/Objectionism/Inquisition (around pp. 89-94), and Languages (p. 135). It avoids importing 2nd Edition continuity into the synopsis.